## Keoladeo National Park



Moving from dry to wet, a wonderful park to visit is **Keoladeo or Bharatpur**, also in Rajasthan. Walking or cycling around this bird sanctuary is a fabulous experience. My most special visit was when I timed it to coincide with a solar eclipse: all the storks and herons returned to their nests as though it were nightfall.

## Sanjay National Park

A central Indian park with a wonderful river system is Sanjay National Park, which now straddles the **border areas of both Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh**. It has beautiful sal forest scenery and if you go in the mahua season, it will also seem extraordinary for the number of sloth bear to be seen.

## Eravikulam National Park

I am not as familiar with the nature reserves of South India, but being a mountain-lover, **Eravikulam and bordering Grass Hills** in the Western Ghats stand out as special for me. I love those high grasslands and nestling shola forests. Seeing elephants in such a surprising setting and meeting Nilgiri tahr and lion-tailed macaques are unforgettable experiences. The 12-yearly bloom of the Neelakuranji (*Strobilanthes kunthiana*) is a mind-blowing adventure; those fantastic green hills turn a most fabulous purple–spectacular.

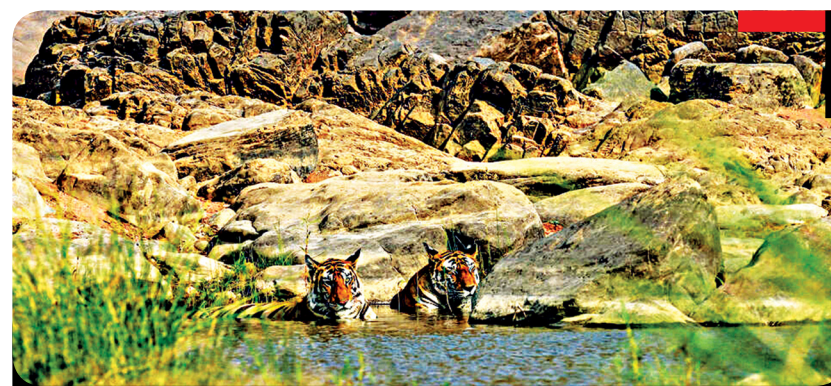


## Manas National Park

The park will always be high on my favourite area list. This is a unique ecosystem in **northeast India, bordering Bhutan**, and is home to the highest number of endangered species of any protected area in India. It also has a fantastic diversity of birds, due to the varied habitats from grassland plain areas and mountain forests to a delightful riverine system. Rare creatures such as the golden langur, pygmy hog, hispid hare and Assam roofed turtle can be found here.

## Coastal Reserves of Odisha

**India also has fantastic mangrove and beach areas and some of the loveliest are in Odisha–Gahirmatha Marine Sanctuary and Rushikulya rookery coast. I once had the unforgettable experience of witnessing a mass hatching of olive ridley turtles. The tiny, strong-flippered little creatures emerge from the sand at night to make their way to the water, attracted by the moonlight-lit waves breaking at the sea edge.**



## Panna National Park

*The Panna National Park in **central India** is also an area with a variety of micro ecosystems supporting a great variety of avian fauna. I love the landscape, the pristine river Ken, the golden grasslands and the rocky escarpments between plateaus. These cliffs provide perfect nesting habitat for some of the resident vultures and the springs at their base provide water for the park's denizens through the long dry season. A visit to this park rarely fails to provide some exciting natural history moment.*